

Resisting Technology's Mechanization of Humanity in a Post-literary Future: Rescuing the Humanities in *Fahrenheit 451*'s War between Intellectualism and Mindlessness

The immediate draw of technology often overshadows the value of literature—in the long-standing opposition between arts and sciences, technology usually receives praise for its practicality, objectivity, and rationality. However, this praise can be one-sided; inverting these qualities reveals a way in which people can degrade literature for its appeal to imagined fantasies, reliance on subjective feeling, and abundance of different interpretations. This staunch divide between the “two cultures” often depicts technology as the superior field of study—one capable of pushing civilization toward the path of progress and building a more convenient world (Snow 82–84). Constructing a binary opposition between art and science portrays the world as a technological utopia, with society embracing the luxuries of instant communication and rampant automation. Our modern society is not too far from this technological world; with the rise of handheld devices and the censorship of books deemed offensive, society affirms an expansion of technology and an abandonment of literature (Bahrani). In these idealistic depictions, written works become afterthoughts as a post-literary society manifests in a perceived effort to improve our world, with people primarily gaining knowledge from electronics, not books.

However, Ray Bradbury's 1953 dystopian novel, *Fahrenheit 451*, reveals that the winner of this perpetual war to improve our world is much more ambiguous—far more complex than the assumption that technology progresses society and literature deteriorates society. Set in an unspecified time in the distant American future, the novel subverts the belief in a technological utopia by presenting a dystopia on the brink of war, where the proliferation of technology does not indicate the presence of a sophisticated human civilization. Rather, technology transforms individuals into emotionless husks more comparable to unthinking machines than intellectual

humans. Following the gradual alienation of former book-burner Guy Montag from the inhabitants of a society completely hostile to reading, *Fahrenheit 451* illuminates the intellectual degradation resulting from the excesses of technology—as Guy appreciates literature and comprehends the world around him, the others extend their vehement disdain for literature and chastise Guy for engaging in “unnecessary, time-wasting thought” (Bradbury 26). His constant disillusionment with the world pushes him to read when he begins to question why he burns books, starting a journey of curious discovery that enlightens him with a better understanding of how books convey messages about the real world. However, when his attempts to spread literature’s messages fail, he escapes the city, vowing to build a better one as the old city’s inhabitants get mercilessly annihilated by bombs. It is the society’s near-universal lack of critical thought that kills its inhabitants, makes *Fahrenheit 451* chiefly dystopian, and reveals an ominous warning that reverberates through the technologically advanced world of the twenty-first century. As one of the books named in school-wide book bans today, *Fahrenheit 451*’s message against the vilification of literature becomes urgent and concrete, as it is precisely this dismissal of reading that generates the novel’s mindless society. Challenging preconceived ideas surrounding the supposedly advantageous dominance of technology over literature, *Fahrenheit 451*’s mechanical characterizations of the society’s inhabitants discourage the unconditional expansion of technology and encourage the incorporation of literature to resuscitate the intellectual mind. Though technology can build worlds, the preventable deaths of the society’s mindless inhabitants demonstrates technology’s concurrent ability to destroy worlds. Such a revelation allows *Fahrenheit 451* to transcend its classification as a work of speculative fiction and instead embody our present, subverting the notion that literature pertains solely to imagined worlds and exposing the possible threat of technology in the modern era.

Fahrenheit 451, whose publication coincides with the rapid rise of television and radio, is often interpreted as a critique of mass culture and technology, with the impending death of individualism seen as the novel's most dystopian aspect. Many scholars, such as Douglas C. Moore and Rafeeq O. McGiveron, emphasize television's role in creating a "conformist culture" that ultimately drowns out the truth (McGiveron 284; Moore 8). These comments understand *Fahrenheit 451* as a warning against the dangers of an obsession with technology, exploring the downfall of literature as a sign of a deteriorating society. However, other scholars, such as Sean McCorry, reveal technology's negative effects on individuals rather than society by arguing that the humans in this society are similar to machines (McCorry 13). The destruction of society and the destruction of individual minds in *Fahrenheit 451*, therefore, are related—technology and mass culture happen to facilitate both by reducing our interest in literature. As new ideas emerge with time, however, *Fahrenheit 451* takes on new meaning, igniting new socio-political discussions as the novel simultaneously receives critical acclaim and experiences censorship. By understanding the novel through the ideas of Jean Baudrillard, scholars like Douglas C. Moore and Hassan Abootalebi place works published after the novel's publication into conversation with *Fahrenheit 451* to argue that obsession with technology ultimately robs us of free will (Abootalebi 12; Moore 16). However, technology's purpose in the novel extends beyond a critique; when understood through C. P. Snow's idea of the two cultures, a clear juxtaposition appears between the technological world and the literary world as Guy rebels against his dystopian prison. This perspective, when combined with the consequences of technology that numerous scholars have identified, reveals the novel's function in shattering the stereotypes surrounding technology and literature by asserting that those invested in technology are not always the innovative thinkers that will generate a better society. Despite their real-world

reputations as practical, objective, and rational thinkers, technological individuals become obsessed with fantasy, dismissive of the truth, and incapable of critical thinking in the novel. Literary individuals, however, get validated and uplifted. *Fahrenheit 451*, then, enters this cultural debate by challenging technology's pristine depiction and placing literature on the same pedestal as technology, rendering the two cultures equally valuable. Although C. P. Snow's lecture debuted after *Fahrenheit 451*'s publication, the underlying concepts still permeate the novel, uncovering how literature and technology do not need to be far apart; both provide mediums for progression and escapism that interact with reality and fantasy.

For example, the drastic downfall of the relationship between Guy Montag and his wife Mildred exposes the presence of two irreconcilable worlds, with Guy living in a literary world and Mildred living in a technological world. Additionally, Mildred's empty responses, juxtaposed with Guy's voice of reason, challenge technology's reputation by characterizing her with the exact opposite qualities that technology generally receives praise for. The praised qualities instead are present within the literary individual, Guy. He mostly asks the questions, reflecting his curious and intellectual mind, while Mildred often dodges them, reflecting her refusal to engage with intellectual thought. This repetitive cycle defines most conversations between them, rendering futile any attempts to unite the two worlds. When Guy confronts Mildred about her overdose, Mildred feigns ignorance by gaslighting her husband, consistently denying the accusation in spite of evidence by repeating that she "didn't do that" and "wouldn't do that" (Bradbury 8–9). Mildred's overdose and subsequent denial of it illustrate her distance from reality, her detachment from the truth, and her potential to act illogically—all inversions of the practicality, objectivity, and rationality commonly associated with people invested in technology. In fact, Mildred, despite being invested in technology, fits more of the negative

stereotypes surrounding literature than the positive stereotypes surrounding technology. Mildred's description, however, is not the exception—it is the norm. This naive behavior does not only reflect negatively on Mildred; it also reflects negatively on “an entire culture”—the world of technology (McGiveron 284). Conversely, Guy shatters the negative stereotypes imposed on the literary world—he acknowledges the reality of impending war, sees the value in books beyond cultural manipulations, and understands that a life glued to three television walls in a single room is unsustainable. He is the only one who continues thinking and carving his own opinions even when others threaten him, while Mildred remains an thoughtless husk who stares at television walls with a “blank expression” (Bradbury 32). Thus, Mildred and Guy are polar opposites—the former remains unwilling to observe her surroundings, while the latter consciously acknowledges the world around him. This impasse ultimately leads to Mildred betraying Guy in a desperate attempt to preserve the world of her television show and remain oblivious to reality. Thus, the inability to join the two worlds destroys the relationship and hinders any progress toward improvement, with the literature-invested Guy living in reality and the technology-obsessed Mildred living in a fantasy.

Furthermore, it is no coincidence that Mildred is simultaneously invested in technology and fantasy, as the television screen she watches creates an immersive, albeit false, simulation of reality that highlights technology's potential to dissociate individuals from the real world. In this sense, the novel directly relates technology and fantasy. Mildred's obsession with the television borders on delusion—when pressured by Guy to turn it off, Mildred retorts by claiming that the people in the show she watches are her “family,” illuminating television's status as a bridge between reality and fantasy (Bradbury 23). In forming a familial bond with characters played by actors, Mildred comes dangerously close to losing herself in an artificial world; she is more

attached to the fictional “Uncle Louis” in the simulated family than the husband in her real family. This attachment with technology ultimately destroys her relationship with Guy—she confidently chooses to abandon her husband after the television wall’s family has completely hypnotized her into thinking that she is part of a different world. Such a revelation reinforces how technology does not solely embrace and enhance reality; it can distort and destabilize reality instead by creating an imitation of it for entertainment (Baudrillard 20–23; Moore 15–18). The television program, then, is not only detached from reality—it actively detaches passive viewers like Mildred from reality, allowing them to temporarily escape it. However, Mildred spends so much time in this technologically created space that it effectively becomes her reality; meanwhile, the world around her becomes a fantasy, rendering Guy as nothing more than a “creature electronically inserted” into the television wall (Bradbury 22). He is no longer a person in Mildred’s eyes—technology leads her to believe that the characters in the television show are real people and that Guy is simply a creature. The television walls immediately and completely capture her attention; to her, anything outside of the television world is a meaningless, unsatisfying imitation. Relationships lose their purpose as interactions with the virtual world begin to supersede interactions with the real world. Therefore, the televisions in this dystopian society not only build a simulated reality—they swap their illusory creations with the real world in the minds of numerous viewers, deliberately eliminating a connection with reality.

This mass reconfiguration of minds by technology ultimately robs the inhabitants of *Fahrenheit 451*’s society of their ability to critically engage with the world to discern fact from fiction, ultimately suppressing their ability to critique the social order. Consequently, the world of *Fahrenheit 451* operates like a machine in which the inhabitants become indistinguishable parts programmed to maintain an unchanging society. With television entrancing nearly

everyone, Guy can no longer start intellectual conversations with anyone because everyone “listens to the walls” instead of actual people—in other words, the television in this world has become a more trustworthy source of information than empirical evidence (Bradbury 38). The characterization of this information source as a “wall” reinforces this deterioration of intellectualism; when Mildred converses with the characters on the television program, she believes that she is part of the parlor family. However, this is merely a mirage. The characters are actually speaking to an anonymous audience—a technological attachment connected to the wall digitally edits the speech to create the illusion that the characters are personally addressing Mildred. This artificial connection makes the television’s lies much more resonant. After alluring viewers with a personal address, the television then tells them what to say, what to do, and what to think, effectively indoctrinating and chaining them by removing their mechanisms for exercising agency. In a society where television hypnotizes nearly all the inhabitants, everyone performs in a homogenous manner to fulfill the vision of a world where people are “made equal” (Bradbury 28). By enforcing uniformity, technology transforms individuals into the cogs of a machine—no one is unique. Technology in *Fahrenheit 451* does not foster human rationality; it erodes individuality and coerces people to uphold rather than challenge societal norms, becoming a fundamental tool to impose widespread thought control. This revocation of intellectual freedom enables mass media to present disinformation as fact. By actively deceiving the inhabitants into believing that everything emanating from the television screen is real and true, society suppresses dissent and silences different perspectives to uphold the status quo.

Thus, by refusing to accept new information, the inhabitants of *Fahrenheit 451*’s society only blind themselves to reality as a result of complete desensitization, insinuating that technology can distract us from our problems rather than solve them. When overhead jets fly

across the sky and produce an ear-splitting noise, they remind the society's inhabitants that war is imminent. However, Mildred and her other technology-obsessed friends have become so attached to the television wall that they refuse to acknowledge the gravity of the situation in the real world, cheerfully stating that wars "come and go" as if they are completely oblivious to the amount of suffering that war inflicts on individuals (Bradbury 44). The nonchalant way they describe this atrocity suggests that war has become such a common occurrence that many people in the society have become completely desensitized to it, thus downplaying its consequences instead of addressing them. In ignoring Guy's repeated pleas to pay attention to the real world, these members of society continue to live in their own technological fantasy under the assumption that everything will be alright, dismissing the very real threat of total annihilation. This refusal to comprehend the danger of war stems from the horrific scenes on the television walls—laughter follows the amputation of limbs, and bodies fly amid a demolition derby (Bradbury 44). Surprisingly, this grotesque gallery does not unsettle anyone in the room—of all the programs on the television walls, this sadistic form of entertainment is Mildred's favorite, and she enthusiastically laughs as the characters suffer. The inhabitants' reaction to violence in the real world mutates to reflect their reaction to violence on the television screen—the victims of tragedy become a comedic spectacle as their misery becomes an amusing experience. Instead of informing individuals about the trauma these experiences inflict, technology distracts from these issues, providing a form of escapism from the world's problems rather than providing us with the tools to confront them (Abootalebi 11; Baudrillard 20–22). Technology's role in bettering society, then, comes under scrutiny. The problems of society—self-destructive behaviors, looming war, and rampant dehumanization—do not get resolved by technology. Technology instead perpetuates these issues or provides an outlet for ignoring them, cultivating

regression rather than progression. Mildred and her friends might believe that technology has created a utopia, but hidden beneath the lies of the television is an overt dystopia that they refuse to acknowledge. In the end, the obsession with technology has pushed them to choose ignorance and allow the dystopia to thrive—their failure to take action thus renders them complicit in society's destruction by exacerbating the problems tormenting society.

Technology's acceleration of the demise of factual information and intellectualism, however, pales in comparison to its ability to annihilate entire worlds through the use of destructive bombs when the impending war finally begins in *Fahrenheit 451*'s climax. This bombing does not just leave the city in ruins, though—the city becomes nothing more than a “heap of baking powder,” totally flattened and dead (Bradbury 74). The description of the city as “baking powder” reveals that only dust remains—the towering buildings and oblivious inhabitants are all vaporized in a fraction of a second. In one moment, there is a thriving city, and in the next moment, years of worldbuilding disappear right before Guy's eyes. Instead of enhancing our world and augmenting our lives, bombs inflict monumental amounts of suffering to maximize casualties—this marvel of technology gives individuals the choice to obliterate societies rather than build them (Nedoh). However, instead of condemning the bomb, *Fahrenheit 451*'s dystopia makes the choice to embrace its destructive potential for personal gain, having engaged in numerous atomic wars; this revelation makes Guy start to question whether everyone has simply “forgotten” the world, insinuating that the others have become so invested in their televised simulation that the real world becomes meaningless and lives become expendable (Bradbury 34). By deluding themselves into thinking this, the inhabitants of *Fahrenheit 451*'s society become destructive agents of society—living in the real world has become so worthless that individuals have started to ignore and even facilitate the bombings of entire cities. Bombs

become tools to erase the remnants of the real world as everyone becomes immersed in a virtual, televised world—after the bombs fly, every person left in the city gets wiped out. Despite this, almost no one attempted to escape the bombing because they never took the threat of imminent war seriously, choosing to remain hedonistic rather than face reality. By chaining everyone to the world of the television wall, technology has dissuaded the city's inhabitants from leaving the city, trapping them in a world on the brink of destruction and condemning them to a brutal death.

However, this fate is not inevitable. Guy, by reading literature pertaining to the suffering inflicted by war, understands that he is unsafe in a city dangerously close to entering a war; literature, then, provides an outlet for individuals to remain attached to the real world and recover from the mind-numbing consequences stemming from an obsession with technology. By escaping the city, Guy narrowly avoids the bombing that pulverizes the society and its inhabitants, becoming one of the only people to survive the beginning of the war. Books open his eyes to the threat of destruction by showing the “pores” of life—the imperfections that permeate all societies but get selectively ignored by this technological society (Bradbury 38). This gives him the power to recognize why this society was doomed to fall—the city's inhabitants were only interested in seeking pleasure and satisfaction from technology, causing them to block out any aspect of the world that would compromise their perception of a perfect space. By reading, Guy learns about the issues that the television walls hide from him, giving him the ability to reflect on the failures of society and develop ways to amend these problems. This allows him to critically think about the world around him instead of passively experiencing it. When Guy finally understands the mistakes that spawned this dystopian society, he finally has the tools to prevent those same mistakes from occurring again. His journey to escape from society takes him to a group of individuals ostracized for their investments in reading—they relate to Guy's

disillusionment with society and have come to the same realization about books that he has.

When the group vows to rebuild the destroyed city, the leader compares humanity to a Phoenix, an immortal, albeit “silly,” bird in Greek mythology that engaged in a permanent cycle of rebirth—the foolish bird would constantly burn itself up and regenerate its body from the ashes left behind (Bradbury 75). Such symbolism parallels the cycle of building and destroying worlds perpetuated by humanity’s tendency to make the same mistakes; the city’s self-destructive obsession with technology emulates the Phoenix’s self-destructive habit of lighting itself on fire. By applying the myth of the foolish Phoenix to the real world, this group of individuals highlights the power of books to reflect the shortcomings of previous societies, helping people create new worlds that will thrive instead of falling victim to the same destructive fates.

Literature, then, reveals the crucial issues that technology seeks to provide an escape from. By allowing for critical reflection, books do not, as commonly believed, just create fictional worlds; they also expose revelations about the real world, creating opportunities for us to end the cycle of creation and destruction by ushering in societies that will finally stand the test of time.

If this is true, then we can similarly apply *Fahrenheit 451*’s warning against technology to the technological world of twenty-first century America, revealing the disturbing similarities between the novel’s dystopia and the modern world. Though the possibility of a future where technology’s convenience superseded any necessity for critical thinking was purely speculative during the novel’s development in the mid-twentieth century, it became prophetic in the digital era. Technology in the real world is much more advanced today—if the novel argues that television’s massive potential for communication inadvertently perpetuates mindless behavior, then there must be a renewed focus on modern mediums of communication and entertainment. In an age where viewers are even more connected with their screens through cell phones and the

Internet, *Fahrenheit 451* becomes representative of our present as children become increasingly distracted by electronic devices and social media (Bahrani). This detachment from reality, echoed in the novel, seeps into our world, as there is a similar trend of using technology to escape our problems and entertain ourselves. Beneath the optimistic facade of peace and tranquility, reality rears its ugly head; reading literature exposes the conglomeration of problems that plague us, while mindlessly scrolling through social media gives us the opportunity to hide from our problems. Though the virtual world of television has migrated to the world of the Internet, political misinformation is ubiquitous, and manipulation is still a major concern. Though books are not literally being set ablaze, school districts in Texas and Florida still control the thoughts of students by banning books that challenge societal norms (Mazzei). Our reliance on technology and dismissal of literature is making us increasingly similar to the inhabitants of the dystopian society in *Fahrenheit 451*; we are losing awareness of the world around us, allowing us to be permanently silenced by modern forms of thought control. The novel, then, transcends its medium of fiction and begins to reflect reality—the stories of the city's inhabitants become cautionary tales, representations of modern individuals whose excessive technology usage walks them down a path of self-destruction (McGiveron 287). *Fahrenheit 451* becomes tightly connected to the contemporary world, serving as a mirror for us to understand our flaws and correct them before we become subjugated to the wills of those in power.

With literature's crucial role in understanding the real world now firmly grounded, technology's role in society becomes ambiguous—it becomes a double-edged sword with the potential to vastly improve society or catalyze its destruction. Though the novel's acknowledgement of technology's merits is often overlooked in scholarship, technology allows Guy to effectively communicate with his literary partner Faber (Bradbury 42). This recognition

hints to us that completely disavowing technology is not the answer; being mindful of how it affects society awards us with the best of both worlds—literary and technological. Society should not shun technology like it did with literature; if completely dismissing literature renders us blind, then completely dismissing technology produces the same effect. *Fahrenheit 451*, then, obliterates preconceived notions of the superiority or inferiority of one culture over another, emulating C. P. Snow's conclusion that the main obstacle to progress in society is the tendency for the two cultures to endlessly denigrate each other instead of sharing crucial knowledge (Snow 74–75). With technology remaining dominant, however, the end of the war between the two cultures will not manifest until we understand the value of literature and the drawbacks of technology. Though technology can optimize lives, when we solely rely on technology to navigate the world, we interact less with our surroundings, exiting our reality and entering a simulation of it. As virtual worlds become more realistic and robots become more human, *Fahrenheit 451* stipulates that we must critically engage with the world to discern fact from fiction, ensuring that we do not become deceived by technology's distortion of reality. If we fail to observe our surroundings and unilaterally embrace escapism, we might permanently imprison ourselves in a dystopia, forfeiting our individuality and becoming a mindless cog in the machine. Guy's victory over an oppressive post-literary society reminds us that even in a contemporary world, we must never abandon our strongest weapon against the loss of individuality—the book.

Works Cited

- Abbootalebi, Hassan. "The Omnipresence of Television and the Ascendancy of Surveillance/Sousveillance in Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451*." *K@ta: A Biannual Publication on the Study of Language and Literature*, vol. 19, no. 1, 2017, pp. 8–14, <https://doi.org/10.9744/kata.19.1.8-14>.
- Bahrani, Ramin. "Why *Fahrenheit 451* Is the Book for Our Social Media Age." *The New York Times*, 10 May 2018, www.nytimes.com/2018/05/10/books/review/fahrenheit-451-ray-bradbury.html.
- Baudrillard, Jean. *Simulacra and Simulation*. Trans. Sheila Faria Glaser. University of Michigan: Ann Arbor, 2004.
- Bradbury, Ray. *Fahrenheit 451*. 1953. Simon & Schuster Paperbacks, 1953.
- Mazzei, Patricia, et al. "Florida at Center of Debate as School Book Bans Surge Nationally." *The New York Times*, 22 Apr. 2023, www.nytimes.com/2023/04/22/books/book-ban-florida.html.
- McCorry, Sean. "Literacy, Betise, and the Production of Species Difference in Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451*." *Extrapolation*, vol. 59, no. 1, 2018, pp. 25–46, <https://doi.org/10.3828/extr.2018.3>.
- McGiveron, Rafeeq O. "'To Build a Mirror Factory': The Mirror and Self-Examination in Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451*." *Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction*, vol. 39, no. 3, Jan. 1998, pp. 282–87, <https://doi.org/10.1080/00111619809599536>.
- Moore, Douglas. *Fahrenheit 451: Temperature Rising*. 2010. Cleveland State University, Master's thesis. *OhioLINK Electronic Theses and Dissertations Center*, http://rave.ohiolink.edu/etdc/view?acc_num=csu1282686419.

Nedoh, Boštjan. “‘Now I Am Become Death, Destroyer of Worlds’: Science, Perversion, Psychoanalysis.” *Journal for Cultural Research*, vol. 24, no. 4, 1 Oct. 2020, pp. 315–333, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14797585.2020.1861811>.

Snow, C. P. *The Two Cultures*. E-book, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008, <https://hdl.handle.net/2027/heb93176.0001.001>.